



Muncie Sanitary District Meeting January 22nd 2025

Meeting Metadata	Details
Video Recording	https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GwQ1RCi-FY8
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Board of Sanitary Commissioners: Meeting Summary

Meeting Date: January 22, 2025

Board Name: Board of Sanitary Commissioners (Muncie Sanitary District)

1. Pre-Meeting Hearings & Committee Work Sessions

The transcript contains no record of a statutory public hearing or committee session held immediately prior to the call to order.

2. Meeting Identification & Attendance

- **Call to Order & Spoken Details:** The meeting was called to order at [00:00:28](#) on January 22, 2025, by the presiding officer of the Board of Sanitary Commissioners.
- **Attendance:**
 - *Present:* All 5 Commissioners (including Mr. Clark, Mr. Smith, Mr. Overton, Mr. Sylvie, and the presiding officer).
 - *Absent:* None (no excused absences reported; quorum achieved).

3. Preliminary & Procedural Business

- **Ceremonial Openings:** The meeting opened with the recitation of the Pledge of Allegiance [00:00:32](#).
 - **Approval of Minutes:** The board reviewed and approved the minutes from the January 8, 2025, board meeting.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote ([00:22:10](#)).
 - **Register of Claims:** Reviewed claims totaling \$837,000.
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote ([00:22:50](#)).
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4. Substantive Business & Board Action

- [00:29:59](#) **Resolution / User Classification Adjustment (Church & Charity Sanitation Rates)**
 - **Sponsor / Presenter:** Board leadership / District Administration.
 - **Deliberation Summary:** The board discussed a recent rate study conducted by the firm Baker Tilly, implemented on January 1, following federal and state mandates to reduce Combined Sewer Overflows (CSO) and invest \$160 million by 2030 to avoid a federal EPA compliance order. Board members acknowledged a severe oversight in the new structure, which inadvertently reclassified churches and not-for-profit institutions into higher-tier institutional/commercial categories, causing massive spikes in monthly sanitation/sewer bills.
 - **Item-Specific Public Input:** Addressed extensively during the public comment period prior to the vote (see Section 5).
 - **Action & Vote Disposition:** Approved by Voice Vote ([00:37:44](#)) to adjust the language submitted by legal counsel to change user classifications (moving churches and charities into the commercial category to ameliorate financial strain, with future adjustments to be considered).
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5. Open Public Comment / Citizen Forum

- [00:01:41](#) **James Heick** (representing Riverside Avenue Baptist Church and speaking as the Historic Preservation Officer): Expressed deep concern over a sanitation bill increase from \$232 to \$2,388.85 per month (a yearly increase of over \$2,164^{<U+2014>}*note: transcript reflects specific billing discrepancies cited by speakers*). Warned that such tax-like burdens threaten the survival of small churches and local historic preservation non-profits. Requested the board provide written justification or rescind/reduce the order.
- [00:05:06](#) **Richard Crabtree** (Pastor, East 20th Southern United Baptist Church): Stated that his small church faced a staggering \$22,400 annual increase, resulting in water shut-offs and threatening closure. Urged caution and understanding regarding the financial realities of small congregations.

- **00:06:27 John Vincent** (91-year-old Deacon, East 16th Street Separate Baptist Church): Spoke as a 60-year member of a 10-person congregation that operates a food bank. Noted that sewage bills jumped from roughly \$30 to \$193, compounding past parking lot runoff fees, and warned it could force the church to sell its property.
- **00:09:04 William Macintosh** (City Council At-Large, Third District): Noted that his own church was affected and shared that he spoke with the mayor, who indicated the drastic spikes were a mistake intended to be corrected.
- **00:09:41 Bobby Joe Beaton** (Bible Holiness Church): Stated that their bill jumped similarly before being temporarily adjusted down after calling staff, emphasizing that churches rely entirely on tithes, receive no government tax subsidies, and provide vital community outreach.
- **00:13:10 Ed Manner** (Trinity United Methodist Church): Voiced concern that severe utility and financial pressures on fixed-income residents and churches will drive people away and harm the community.
- **00:14:20 Harold Mason** (6th District City Councilman): Urged the board to revisit Ordinance 25-01, pointing out that churches operate only a couple of days a week with minimal water consumption and cannot afford the steep base rates.
- **00:15:37 Melissa McDaniel** (Small business owner / fourplex owner): Shared that her small commercial property bill doubled despite having less than half the water usage of previous years, warning that compounding utility and insurance costs are crushing small businesses and emptying Muncie's commercial corridors.
- **00:17:11 Judy Cary** (Trinity United Methodist Church): Financial administrator for her church; expressed shock at receiving a \$1,195 base rate sanitation bill for a church occupied only 3-4 hours a week. Highlighted compounding property and liability insurance hikes and the struggle of senior citizen congregations to pay essential bills.
- **00:20:52 Mike Overbay** (Associate Pastor, New Horizon Nazarene): Echoed concerns regarding unsustainable billing increases for small, older congregations attempting to run neighborhood blessing boxes and community outreach.

6. Administrative Updates & Adjournment

- **Staff / Board Announcements:**
 - **District Administrator Rick Conrad (00:23:05):** Reported seven open positions across departments (laborers, wastewater operator, plant electrician); recognized field crews working in sub-zero weather with cold-weather gear and pay bumps; announced a new IT email-phishing educational campaign led by Tim Stover; and acknowledged engineering department employee Doug McLennan, who is retiring on January 31 after 27 years of service.
 - **Water Pollution Control Facility Superintendent Jason Ingram (00:27:00):** Reported that the facility treated 5.8 billion gallons of wastewater and sent 8,455 tons of biosolids to the landfill in 2024; detailed the successful replacement of

1976-era pumps at MCA Park lift station; noted progress on removing CSO 13 from the state permit; announced the arrival of a new CNG sludge dump truck (qualifying for a \$90,000 Drive Clean Indiana grant); and mentioned upcoming fleet vehicle purchases through sourcewell.

- **Adjournment:** The meeting was officially adjourned by voice vote at the conclusion of the session (00:40:51).

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